

PEAKS AND PRAIRIES

North America

The world's third largest continent is bordered by the Pacific, Arctic, and Atlantic oceans, and the Caribbean Sea. Geographically, Greenland and the islands of the Caribbean are considered part of North America. Most of the continent occupies

a single plate, with small parts of Mexico and California lying on the neighboring Pacific plate, which abuts the North American plate along the infamous San Andreas fault. The mountain ranges of the Western Cordillera have a profound influence on the climate of the west side of the continent.

For example, rainshadow deserts form on the mountains' eastern flanks. Smaller, more ancient mountain ranges follow the eastern coast, while much of the interior of North America is low-lying.

The vast north-south extent of the continent means it encompasses a wide range of climate types, from Arctic cold to tropical heat. Dominant ecosystems include tundra, boreal and temperate forest, prairie, desert, and extensive wetlands. These diverse habitats support an impressive range of animals, from the largest mammals—American bison and bears—to alligators living in the swamps and wetlands of the southeast.

CANADIAN SHIELD

Extending north from the Great Lakes to the Arctic Ocean is one of the world's largest geologic continental shields (exposed Precambrian crystalline rocks). The rocks of the Canadian Shield have remained above sea level for almost 4 billion years. Soils form a thin layer or are absent as the rocks have been scoured by ice during repeated glaciations.



ALEUTIAN ISLANDS

An arc of 69 volcanic islands, largely treeless and fogbound, that support an array of plant life and seabird colonies.

ARCTIC OCEAN

